righteous suspicion of Hindus – Badauni reveals himself a far more complicated character than his patron. Thus, for example, the future diarist embarked upon a scandalous love affair soon after he was made sadr.

Badauni does not say whether the object of his affection was male or female, only that ‘I was captured in the net of desire and lust’ and ‘committed a terrible . . . impropriety’ in – of all places – a shrine. Badauni’s beloved’s relatives were appalled. A group of them attacked the sadr. One of their swords ‘penetrated the bone of my skull, and reached the brain’, recalls Badauni, mortified, ‘exposing me as a brainless fellow’.

By contrast, Abul Fazl appears innocent of the ways of the world. He was ten years Badauni’s junior, and describes himself as a shy, bookish man, uninterested in the glamour of court life. ‘I was not inclined to do this,’ he writes, ‘and my . . . apprehensions of the social state disturbed my soul, which was inclined to solitude.’ It was his elder brother, Faizi, already a poet in Akbar’s employ, and his father, Shaikh Mubarak, who pressed the young scholar to show a little more enterprise.

For all his naivete, however, real or assumed, Abul Fazl was as immersed as Badauni in the political and social currents of his time; indeed, his family was almost washed away by them. Briefly, Abul Fazl’s father, Shaikh Mubarak, was a Mahdawi; he believed, that is, in a millenarian movement that gathered pace in the tenth century of the Hijri calendar (c. 1494–1592), and held that a final messiah, the last Mahdi, would descend upon the world at the dawn of the second Islamic millennium (1000 AH or 1591–92 CE).[11]

As the great day approached, Mahdawis proliferated, and self-proclaimed Mahdis, too, arose aplenty across Hindustan. While Humayun was still on his long exile from Hindustan, one of these Mahdis, Shaikh Alai, created a stir in the Suri court,[12] attracting many, including Shaikh Mubarak, to his fold. Like any belief that promises radical change, the movement of the Mahdawis was inimical to the establishment. Shaikh Ala’i (and Shaikh Mubarak along with him) made powerful enemies.

The most powerful of these was a highly regarded jurist called Maulana Abdullah Ansari, titled Makhdum-ul-Mulk, ‘one who is served by the realm’. It was largely by Makhdum-ul-Mulk’s doing that Shaikh Ala’i was banished from the Suri court and then died. The death was ‘a great triumph’ for the court scholars, who followed it with a ‘vigorous persecution of all